made major concessions. This saw the return of vintage RSS man Ram Madhav to the BJP in August to deal with the J&K polls and the deployment of Sangh *sah-sarkaryavahs* Arun Kumar (in Haryana), Atul Limaye (Maharashtra) and Alok Kumar (Jharkhand) for election coordination. Their job apparently was to "reactivate the core voters and re-enthuse the sympathisers".

Sangh sources say workers from 65 affiliate organisations were on the ground in Maharashtra and some 150,000 small to large meetings were held. Even the poll assignments to Union minister and Nagpur native Nitin Gadkari had the Sangh's hand written all over it. The poll results have since shown how crucial the larger Sangh Parivar is to the success of the party.



The pattern was similar—make the contest about local issues, not Modi vs the Others. This helped the BJP set the agenda, make best use of RSS resources

The New Template

Unlike in the past, when PM Modi used to do much of the heavy lifting in poll campaigns, the party has been more strategic in how much he is exposed on the frontline. In his third term, the prime minister held just five rallies in Haryana, 10 in Maharashtra and four in Jharkhand. The pattern has been—make the contest about local issues, not about Modi versus the Others. This has allowed the BJP to set the agenda and also make best use of the massive RSS organisation.

The PM is also adopting a softer line. So, while he mouths the milder rhetoric, like the slogan "*Ek hai to safe hai* (United, we are safe)", it is left to the likes of Uttar Pradesh chief minister Yogi Adityanath and his Assam counterpart Himanta Biswa Sarma to push the harder Hindutva line. Accordingly, Yogi campaigned with the slogan '*Batenge to katenge* (Divided, we'll be felled)' and 'vote jihad' in Maharashtra, and Sarma sounded a 'Muslim infiltration' alarm in Jharkhand, alleging that the tribal Santhal Parganas area was turning into a "mini Bangladesh".

The PM is also becoming measured in his reaction to Opposition campaigns. For instance, his choice not to retaliate to their ongoing '*Samvidhan bachao* (save the Constitution)' protest has ensured that the issue is not catching fire a second time. And while he continues to take on national figures like the Gandhi family, PM Modi avoids attacking local grandees, such as Sharad Pawar and Uddhav Thackeray in Maharashtra. BJP insiders say it's part of a deliberate strategy, as in Maharashtra, and allowed the party to control the narrative and make the contests very local rather than becoming a Modi versus Pawar or a Modi versus Uddhav battle.

In a related intervention by the Sangh, the BJP is also allowing local satraps to have more say in electoral campaigns. Gadkari stationed himself in Maharashtra's Vidarbha region, holding 73 rallies. The RSS also ensured he had a say in candidate selection and campaign design. The result: the BJP-led Mahayuti won 40 of the 62 assembly seats in the region. In the LS polls, farmers' distress and the Maratha agitation had helped the Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA) alliance win seven of the 10 constituencies here.

Similarly, Mahayuti ally Ajit Pawar's Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) was allowed to defy the Hindutva line in western Maharashtra. The BJP think-tanks realised their hardline slogans were not working here; an added complication was the local cadre unhappy at allying with Ajit. That had reflected in the Lok Sabha polls, when the NDA was wiped out in the region. The Sangh's job was to ensure the BJP and Shinde Sena votes got transferred to Ajit's candidates, despite his defiant posturing. This is a playbook used in Haryana too, when satraps like Union ministers Rao Inderjit Singh and Krishanpal Gurjar were allowed to 'innovate' in the campaign.

Saffron Twist to *Revdi*

For all the distaste PM Modi and others have expressed for the '*revdi* (dole)' culture, few in the BJP dispute its importance in 'election messaging'. The RSS cadre ensured that they relayed the messaging effectively to the grassroots. The Sangh apparatus started constituency-wise deployment from August onwards